



The French government saw the growth of German civil aviation as a direct threat to its interests. As a consequence, it poured money into its own passenger network. By 1920 eight French airlines were operating, each with its own monopoly route and subsidy. Britain lagged behind in the promotion of passenger transportation, but in 1924, after a series of air-transport ventures had struggled to survive without subsidy, the British government promoted a merger to form Imperial Airways, a private company officially backed as the nation's "chosen instrument." The logic of the situation eventually led to the creation of a single state airline in both France (Air France, founded in 1933) and Britain (BOAC, founded in 1939).

Even the smaller European countries had to have their own airline, and at least one of these "flag carriers" was outstandingly successful. Founded in 1919, the Dutch airline Koninklijke Luchtvaart Maatschappij (KLM) was the brainchild of army pilot Albert Plesman. Working closely with Fokker, who supplied KLM with some of the best passenger aircraft around, Plesman made his company a notable presence in world aviation despite the lack of a significant domestic network. By 1929 KLM was regularly flying an eight-day route from the Netherlands to Batavia (now Jakarta) in the Dutch East Indies – the longest scheduled service in the world.

Converted warplanes

The first passenger services after the war used converted bombers or reconnaissance aircraft. It was these airplanes that gave passengers the

CROSS-CHANNEL SERVICE

During the General Strike of 1926, cross-Channel air traffic greatly increased due to the cancellation of ferry services. Imperial Airways took advantage of this with its daily London–Paris service, here using a Handley Page W.10.

rawest experience of flight, since they were simply occupying seats that would once have held an observer or bomb-aimer. For instance, in the Handley Page O/11, a converted O/400 bomber, two of the passengers had balcony seats in the open bow, combining an astonishing view with total exposure to the elements. As custom-built passenger aircraft emerged, Britain and France largely stuck with biplanes, such as the de Havilland D.H.34, while the German and Dutch airlines flew more modern monoplanes such as the Junkers F 13 and Fokker F.III. Through the 1920s, Fokker and Junkers evolved these single-engine airplanes into multiengine models that remained world leaders until the United States muscled into commercial aviation in the following decade.

As air travel became better organized through the 1920s, traveling in a custom-built passenger airplane became a passably civilized experience. Climbing into an F-13,

RECORD-BREAKING FOKKER

The Fokker F.XVIII airliner, introduced to KLM airlines in 1932 and seen in this promotional poster of the time, cut down the traveling time to the Dutch East Indies to nine days. A year later, an airmail-only trip was achieved in a record time of four days.

HUGO JUNKERS

PROFESSOR HUGO JUNKERS (1859–1935)

was almost 50 years old when he first took an interest in aviation. A professor at Aachen College, he began exploring the aerodynamic possibilities of metal cantilever wings and, in 1910, patented a revolutionary design for an all-metal airplane without a fuselage or tail, housing the engines, crew, and passengers in the wing. This "flying wing" was never built, but during World War I, other Junkers all-metal designs were adopted by the German air forces. At the end of the war, Junkers instructed his team to turn their efforts to civil air transportation.

Junkers Flugzeugwerke went on to produce outstanding aircraft, from the F-13 to the Ju 52, while Junkers also established a short-lived but highly successful airline business. When the Nazis came to power in 1933, the independent-minded Junkers was one of their first targets, and he was bullied into handing over his company and his personal patents to the state. He was put under house arrest and died on his 76th birthday in 1935.



INSPIRED DESIGNER

At a time when most of his competitors were creating strut-and-wire, fabric-covered biplanes, Junkers was producing all-metal, cantilever-wing monoplanes that pointed the way forward for aircraft design.

